Russians can use the rhetoric of historical exclusion and exploitation to lobby African leaders to give them lucrative contracts in the exploitation and processing of natural resources, construction projects, and arms deals. Russia–Africa relations reached their peak in the 1960s, which incidentally coincided with the wave of independence in various countries in the continent. Russia–Africa relations then regressed significantly in 1991 when Boris Yeltsin, the first president of the Russian Federation, declared that 'Russia's policy of foreign aid would be halted and that Russia would ask African countries to repay their debts as soon as possible.' This period also coincided with the dissolution of the Soviet Union and the introduction of the market economy in Russia.

Russia–Africa relations are taking a new turn now due to Russia's search for new natural resources, and market niches for Russian goods. Russia also needs the support of developing countries to strengthen its voice in different bodies of the United Nations around pressing issues such as the Chechnya and Crimea crises, international conflicts, violations of human rights, and lack of freedom of expression of individuals who oppose or call for regime change.

The priorities of Russia for its foreign economic strategy in the region include but are not limited to the following: (1) prospecting, mining, oil, construction and mining, purchasing gas, uranium, and bauxite assets (Angola, Nigeria, Sudan, South Africa, Namibia, etc.); (2) construction of power facilities – hydroelectric power plants on the River Congo (Angola, Zambia, Namibia, and Equatorial Guinea) and nuclear power plants (South Africa and Nigeria); (3) creating a floating nuclear power plant, and South African participation in the international project to build a nuclear enrichment centre in Russia; (4) railway construction (Nigeria, Guinea, and Angola); and (5) creation of Russian trade houses for the promotion and maintenance of Russian engineering products (Nigeria and South Africa).

Prospecting and mining represent the first priorities of Russia's foreign economy policy to gain access to a source of supply of key minerals – e.g. zinc, manganese, copper, nickel, and platinum – which are essential for the functioning of a modern economy but will be depleted within the next decade or become difficult to access and costly to develop. Africa is the best destination for the new scramble because of the availability of these resources and the lower costs of exploitation. Russia also has military and arms interests in Africa. Indeed, Russia is the second largest arms exporter, which in 2011 amounted to a total value of US$66.8 billion.

Most of these activities occur through five major Russian companies, alone or in partnership with other MNCs: